

CHARTING A NEW COURSE

In Indian rowing, where the larger story has often been shaped by men, the IIS facility in Vijayanagar is an attempt to give women rowers a **system for success.**

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At the Inspire Institute of Sport's (IIS) water sports facility in Vijayanagar, Karnataka, the early-morning stillness soon gives way to the scrape of boats and the shuffle of oars. Athletes carefully carry their equipment to the lake, where the water stretches a little over two kilometres — close to the international 2000m racing distance — and is framed by a landscape far removed from India's usual training centres.

Then the work begins.

The rowers arrive early, carrying their boats down the embankment. Once on the water, they settle into repetition. Morning sessions can cover anywhere from 12km to 16km. A race lasts only 2000m, but the preparation for those few minutes is built on hours of controlled suffering.

Indian rowing's larger story has often been shaped by the men, especially by the Army Rowing Node in Pune, a programme that has had time to mature and produce international results. Women's rowing has had to build its pathway with less depth and fewer comparable systems. That is the gap IIS is trying to address.

Its water sports programme, launched earlier this year, has around 20 women rowers.

Already, two boats training here have moved into the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games picture: the women's double sculls and the women's coxless pair. In double sculls, each rower uses two oars. In the coxless pair, each has one oar and no coxswain to call rhythm or steer. Trust becomes as important as power, and a single lapse in timing can cost precious speed.

Nutritionist Natanya Bhatt says the 2000m event places a heavy demand on carbohydrates, with regular monitoring of recovery and energy levels.

For the athletes, that support matters because the margins are tight. India is no longer trying merely to participate at the Asian level; it is trying to remain in medal contention.

From Chandigarh to Aichi-Nagoya

Diljot Kaur understands that shift.

At the 2025 Asian Rowing Championships in Hai Phong, Vietnam, she and Gurbani Kaur gave Indian women's rowing a result it had waited 15 years for, winning silver in the lightweight coxless pair — India's first women's medal at the continental championships since 2010.

"Even before taking part in the competition, I had decided that if I represented India, I would win a medal and come back," Diljot told *Sportstar*. "I manifested it so much that it came true. We lost seven kilograms each for that



For India's women rowers, the next few months will be about taking the promise seen in training and holding it under continental pressure.